In this process three main periods can be distinguished. The first, from the time of Howard's appearance as prison reformer until 1835 may be called the period of Private Endeavour; the second, from 1835 to 1877 that of National Supervision; the third, from 1877 to the present day, that of National Administration.

The first period contains many famous names—Blackstone, Eden, Romilly, Nield, Paul, Buxton, Elizabeth Fry—and these kept burning the torch kindled by Howard. But the prisons generally showed little sign of improvement, save in isolated cases where the local authorities were exceptionally conscientious. Acts passed in 1779 and 1791, the first for the establishment of a National Penitentiary, the second applying the principles of the penitentiary to all places of detention, were inoperative. Prison fees were abolished by law in 1815, but there was no inspection to see that the abolition was effected. In 1823 Peel, then Home Secretary, introduced and passed the first Government measure dealing with the gaols. This was largely a consolidating act, reaffirming the various principles which had before (in 1779 and 1791) been enacted and neglected, and making it the duty of the justices to furnish quarterly reports to the Home Secretary on the condition of their gaols. But this measure again failed to institute any machinery to enforce its provisions and, moreover, applied only to the county gaols, leaving untouched the majority of the borough and franchise gaols as well as the great London debtors' prisons, with results that may be appreciated from a reading of *Pickwick Papers* and *Little Dorrit*.

In 1835, however, a real advance was made under the reformed Parliament, and a bill was passed which applied to all prisons, not merely those included in Peel's act, and which for the first time established inspectors. Thus the period of National Supervision was inaugurated.

National Supervision implies a national policy. Some sort of standard had to be set before the more lax of the local authorities, some sort of course steered between the conflicting principles followed out by the others.

Following an enormous increase in the prison population in the eighteen-twenties, which Sidney Smith among others attributed to the comparative attractions of some of the better regulated gaols, deterrence became the watchword, and the era of the treadmill and the crank began. At the same

time reasonable standards of hygiene and organisation were exacted from the more recalcitrant authorities, reformatories were established, and on the whole the prison population benefited. The scandal of Birmingham Gaol in 1853, however, the subject of Charles Reade's novel, *It's Never Too Late to Mend*, showed what horrors could be perpetrated under conditions of even limited local autonomy, and paved the way for the acts of 1865 and 1877, under which the prisons finally became the sole charge of the State. But it was motives of public economy which finally determined this step, because the absurdity of having a prison in each borough, to hold perhaps half a dozen prisoners, had become patent with the improvement of communications.

Under unitary control there was perfected a uniform prison system which up to a point would have won Howard's unstinted admiration. Every prisoner had a spotlessly clean and airy cell, gaol officials were all salaried public servants, under constant supervision from the Home Office, rigid order was everywhere enforced, so that the mere idea of drunkenness in a prison became grotesque.

But Howard would have been quick to notice that the young beginner was confined together with the old offender, and those guilty of trifling offences with both. He would have noticed that certain tasks then performed (for instance on the crank) seemed, as he had once said, calculated merely to torment the prisoners. He would have noticed, above all, that there was a complete absence of humanity in all prisons: that it was made utterly impossible for a prisoner to receive a service or a kindness from another prisoner, and very nearly impossible for him to receive these things from an official or an outside philanthropist. He would have noticed that as a result of these things the great majority of prisoners still came out worse men than they had gone in. Or more probably he would have been unable to notice any of these things, because the authorities would have taken great care never to have let a meddling amateur like Howard inside a gaol wall.

Since the beginning of the century, and especially during the past few years, an attempt has been made to remedy these defects. Borstal Institutions and separate establishments for young prisoners have been introduced, but still there are prisons where the old offender and young beginner are not wholly separated. The crank was abolished at the end of